

Vertigo

No 819 July 2018



NEW ZEALAND
ALPINE CLUB

Wellington Section Monthly Bulletin

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Approaching the second ice pitch at about 2,670m
on the SE Ridge of Te HeuHeu. More [here](#)

Chair's Report

July 2018

The club is facing a bit of a crisis in relation to its courses. We are being squeezed between the beginner level courses of tramping clubs and the costly private sector courses of professional operators. This is partly due to the NZAC guidelines which expect sections to use Alpine 2 instructors at a 6:1 ratio on Advanced courses, yet the NZAC isn't prepared to invest in training volunteers to gain and maintain this level of qualification. This is tantamount to requiring paid instructors to run our courses, which flies in the face of the volunteer ethos of the club.

From a Wellington section perspective there are a number of issues with this. First, the ratio is two low. We normally run at 2:1 ratio. This provides optimal student engagement and safety. As a result, feedback from students on the quality of our courses is consistently positive and our safety record 100% since adopting this approach. We are able to do this by using a mix of qualified and unqualified (but experienced) volunteers as opposed to paid instructors.

Second, if we are forced to use a paid instructor, our course cost will skyrocket, putting them out of financial reach of most of our students, who are our main source of new members. This doesn't seem to be understood by professional guides who claim we should be paying them to run our courses. Using professional guides, who rely on getting people to hire them, to advise on what the club should do on its volunteer courses is a direct conflict of interest for the club. Several of the guides I've spoken to see volunteer instruction as taking away their business. Guides are generally great people, if not occasionally on the arrogant side, but this view is particularly short sighted. Students are there to learn, not be guided. Plus, the cost of hiring a guide is far more expensive than building some skills and going on your own trips.

I'm not against having qualified instructors oversee our courses. On the contrary, and regardless of changes to the Health and Safety Act, it is our duty of care to ensure our courses are run as safely as possible. We don't need to pay professional guides to do this. The level of instruction expected by students is at the low end of technical ability. At the core skills level, students are generally beginners, have little or no equipment and are just looking to gain some skills on moving on snow and ice so they can deal with these conditions when tramping at higher altitude. To impart these skills does not require exposing anyone to serious harm. Even at the highest level of our course, there is no requirement to put students in harm's way in order to impart the skills. Course safety doesn't require a paid professional, it requires a culture of safety informed by good decision making.

Contrary to arguing that the club should hand over its courses to professional guides, the guiding world would do better to recognise that, by investing in volunteer instruction, they benefit from those students that graduate to more ambitious adventures and who then hire guides to get them there.

Similarly, using guides for instructor development has much the same problem. Guides might have awesome skills when it comes to getting people up and down mountains safely but that doesn't make them good instructors. I've been on several years of club instructor development courses and, with few exceptions, have learnt little from them either technically or on instructing. Many of the sessions seemed to treat the instructors as though they were clients. Fortunately this didn't apply to all the guide / instructors. Those that work for instructing institutions seemed a much better fit for requirements. Maybe because they spend more time instructing than guiding, where the outcome they are seeking isn't a summit but an improved ability for students.

Finally, in spite of the guidelines, no guide or other instructor has joined any of our courses to observe their delivery and so be in a better position to determine if we are applying best practice. Maybe this would provide a more informed basis for deciding who and how to run our courses.

Tell me and I forget, teach me and I may remember, involve me and I learn."
Benjamin Franklin

If you have any comments on what you like or don't like send an email to wellington@alpineclub.org.nz or tweet us [@NZACWellington](https://twitter.com/NZACWellington).

Simon

From the Editor

I've started to receive entries for our annual Wellington Section photo competition, but we need lots more. Don't forget - closeoff for entires is 12th August - not that far away! [More here](#).

No trip reports received again this month. Come on folks, it's pretty easy and it would be great to share more of our adventures. Just type up a report of between half and three pages as a Word document, email it to occasionalclimber@gmail.com with one to six jpeg images and I'll format it for Vertigo.

Peter

Simon Williamson
Chair: NZAC Wellington

Section News

August Section night

From 6pm Wed 29th August, it's the annual Wellington Section Photo Competition judging evening.

All Section night talks are held at The Third Eye, Tuatara Brewery, level 2, 30 Arthur Street, from 6pm. Also a good place to collect or return hired climbing gear.

Section nights beyond August

Wed 26th September, Penny Webster will take us through her quest to climb all of New Zealand's 3,000m peaks.

Wed 31st October, Nigel Roberts will present his journey up the highest peaks in each of USA's 50 states.

Wed 28th November, Nina Sawicki will take us on a journey to Kanchenjunga base camp in Nepal.

No section nights December and January.

Wed 27th February 2019, climbing and pizzas at Hangdogs TBC

Wed 27th March, Paul Maxim will talk about peaks, places and prints - as a climber and writer, how he has been able to very successfully combined these two interests.



The Pouakai tarn. [More here](#)

Section News

Gear Hire

Don't forget the Section has gear for hire: avalanche transceivers, ice axes, shovels, stakes, hammers, helmets, crampons, probes, PLBs, ice hammers (entry level).

To hire gear please fill in the form [here](#). Why not come to a last Wednesday of the month Section evening to collect or return gear.

Each item costs \$5 per week with the exception of PLBs – PLBs are free but require a deposit of \$50 refundable on return.

A little bit of advance notice would be appreciated as gear often needs to be retrieved from the gear store in Lower Hutt. Gear collections and drop-offs are usually available in the city during the working day or at section night.

Accommodation on Mt Ruapehu

Our snowcraft courses for the past few years have been run out of the Manawatu Tramping and Skiing Club lodge on Whakapapa. We're always made to feel welcome and the lodge is well situated a short walk from the top of the Bruce Road. Membership to the club is extremely reasonable - \$35 per year or \$50 for a family membership. Members stay at the lodge for \$36 a night including food. If you're looking for somewhere to base yourself for your winter pursuits or rock-climbing over the summer months go to www.mtsc.org.nz/joining.php to find out more about joining the club.

Nominations open for NZAC Volunteer of the Year 2018

NZAC Volunteer of the Year (VOTY) is awarded at each AGM. Individuals and Sections nominate an NZAC volunteer that they think have done great work over the course of the previous year. Please complete the [online nomination form](#) no later than 1 Oct 18.

American Alpine Club 2018 International Climbers' Meet, Yosemite Valley

The American Alpine Club is hosting its 10th annual International Climbers' Meet (ICM), to be held the week of Oct 7th - Oct 14th, 2018 in Yosemite Valley. There will be three days of education programming, host climbers available for guidance, and, per usual, an international cast of characters that will be crushing Yosemite. More [here](#).

Notices

NZAC instruction courses open for registration

Click for more details - [Ice Climbing](#) [Ski Touring](#) (and the new guide [here](#))

Applications for the 2018 FMC Expedition Scholarships now open

FMC is proud to offer Youth Scholarships (age under 30) for the eighth year running, and the Simon Bell Memorial Scholarship (no age restrictions) for the third consecutive year. To enquire [email](#) our Executive Officer. Applications close on Friday 14 September 2018.

Ski-fields offering NZAC members a discount for the 2018 season

Cross Country Rentals NEW 10% discount to members

Please present your active NZAC membership card at the time of quoting for a discount.

Cross Country Rentals has 12 locations nationwide from Christchurch to Auckland, [contact us now!](#)

* Subject to vehicle availability

* Discount does not apply to hires 15 days or longer

* Discount applies to hire charges only.

Outdoor first aid course

Outdoor Training is running an outdoor first aid course on the weekend of 1-2 September. There are still some spaces available on the course and people can do the whole course or just the refresher. Those interested can [email](#) to get further details.

UIAA ice climbing season

The calendar for the 2019 UIAA ice climbing season is now in place. Read [more](#).

2018 UIAA Mountain Protection Award - applications now open

As a member of the UIAA the NZAC is eligible to enter individual or group projects for this award. Please email the General Manager, [Karen Tait](#), if you have a project for entry. The UIAA Mountain Protection Award (MPA) was created in 2013. During its six years of existence, the annual UIAA Mountain Protection Award (MPA) has made a tangible difference to mountain lives, communities and the environment. It has enabled people to raise finances to build key infrastructures, conduct vital research and fulfil pending goals; it has provided an international showcase and communication platform for projects to raise awareness and exchange ideas and initiatives. Not only has it supported local communities, it has fostered its own global community. The Award celebrates innovation and a desire to make a difference. [Click](#) for more.

AHT's 2018 Inspiring Explorers' Expedition to Greenland has begun

Attempting a crossing of the ice cap, the team will traverse 560km on skis and the journey will take about a month. Follow the expedition [here](#) and on our Facebook and Instagram channels.

Expedition Fund 2018 [Call for Applications and Donations](#)

XII ISMM World Congress On Mountain Medicine

21-24 November 2018, Kathmandu, Nepal, www.ismm2018.org, [email](#)

International Snow Science Workshop preliminary programme [here](#)

Coming Trips, Courses, Events

All our planned South Island trips come with the added bonus that rental vehicle costs for Wellington Section members are covered by the Section.

If you're uncertain about the skill level required with any of the trips, would like to register your interest or to find out more, email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz.

Also, please contact us if you're keen to run a trip yourself – the Committee can help with advertising and logistics.

When	What and where
TBA depending on level of interest	Self rescue course for new comers Titahi Bay, expressions of interest sought wellington@alpineclub.org.nz
26 Jul and 3 - 5 Aug	Beginner Winter Snowcraft Course - full, on waitlist
9 and 17 - 19 Aug	Beginner/Intermediate Winter Snowcraft Course - full, on waitlist
16 and 24 - 26 Aug	Intermediate/Advanced Winter Snowcraft Course - full, on waitlist To register for any of these courses click here or contact wellington@alpineclub.org.nz
July/August	Wellington Section Annual Photo Competition Judging evening Wed 29 August. Email your entries now. Details here >>>
26 Aug	National Annual Photo Competition Entries received until this date. More here .
27 Aug to 7 Sep	Have your say Online member voting on proposed governance changes More details to follow
5 to 7 October	North Island Ski Touring Meet 2018 Based at Tukino Lodge, Mt Ruapehu Info Pack Registration Please contact Mac with any questions A great opportunity to find likeminded people, enjoy some spring ski touring adventures with them and explore Ruapehu's wild side, away from the busy ski fields. Please note this is not a led trip, so when on the meet, groups will need to be able to look after yourselves when away from the lodge.
16 to 19 November	Wellington Section Climbing Meet - Paines Ford, Takaka Contact Eric Duggan for more information or to confirm your spot For members, your transport from the airport to Hangdog Camp ground is subsidised. This is a climbing meet, not an instruction course. You must be able to belay and lead in an outdoor environment and have your own safety and climbing equipment. It is not required to have rope or quickdraws but you need to buddy up with others that have them. Hangdog Camp grounds is the usual accomm situation but you can organise alternative accommodation.
13 - 27 April 2019	Wellington Section Trip to Arapiles Please email your expression of interest to Jenny Cossey Fly to Melbourne individually and leave by car in a group from Melbourne on Saturday 13th April. Returning by car to Melbourne on Saturday 27th April. Please note these are the two weeks of the NZ school holidays which includes Good Friday (19th April), Easter Monday (22nd April) and ANZAC Day (25th April). Please book your own air tickets early to suit you. The Wellington section will give a subsidy towards car hire for the trip for a maximum of ten section members who register with the trip organiser Jenny Cossey on a first come first served basis.

Annual Photo Wellington Section Competition

The 2018 competition is now open to enter, so polish up your favourite contenders and get them in.

Image submission requirements:

- Images must be submitted by email as jpeg attached files to occasionalclimber@gmail.com along with a caption, the category, who the photographer is and where and when the image was taken.
- Please ensure you have permission from people in your photos that their image can be used and possibly published in Vertigo.
- The **closing date** for the competition is the **12th August** and the winners will be announced at the section night on Wednesday 29th August.

7 categories to enter. Up to 3 images per category:

- Alpine Activity • Alpine General • Alpine Nature • Rock climbing
- Mountain and Climbing Culture • Humour • Alpine Kids

[More details next page >>>](#)



Three days of gales and white out at Pioneer hut 2,378m
Iain Burgon, Winner, Mountain and Climbing Culture 2017



Annual Photo Wellington Section Competition

Entry into the annual FMC photo competition

Category winners and selected honours awards will be entered by NZAC Wellington into the FMC annual photo competition in September (deadline 15th for clubs).

Category details. Up to 3 images per category:

- **Alpine Activity: climbing, skiing, whatever you do up high**
Photographs where the main subject is people engaging in activity in the alpine environment (e.g. climbing, skiing, tramping, camping). Emphasis on careful composition and 'capturing the moment'.
- **Alpine General: scenery and views that make you want to come back**
Photographs that display mountain landscapes. Images should be strongly composed with great light. Judges will be weighing technical excellence, colour, tone and detail along with the image's subject and composition.
- **Alpine Nature: the little gems of beauty along the way**
Photographs of natural subjects in the mountain environment, where the emphasis is on artistic rendition. Subjects may include geological features, plants (or parts of plants), animals, water, snow and ice formations, etc.
- **Rock climbing: hardest moves, slickest lines**
Photographs of rock climbing and bouldering that have strong visual impact and creative composition.
- **Mountain and Climbing Culture: climbing life, places and people**
Portray climbing life, places and people encountered by climbers. Entries might include travel photography (as long as it's strongly related to climbing) or documentary-style images, covering any aspect of climbing.
- **Humour: whatever makes you smile**
Don't forget the caption. Particularly in this category it can make the difference.
- **Alpine Kids**
Alpine / climbing-related photos taken by kids aged 6 to 14 (please include age of the child when submitting entries in this category).

Image Specifications:

- All images must have been taken and processed by the competitor and be their property.
- Images need not necessarily have been taken in New Zealand.
- Entries are permitted in digital format only. Files must be JPEG format between 500KB and 5MB (at least 2000 pixels on the long side).
- Digital processing should be mostly restricted to dust removal, cropping, resizing, exposure and tonal adjustments. HDR, and exposure, focus or sequence blending are permitted. Obvious modification of images is not in keeping with the objectives of this competition and may result in disqualification.
- Images not meeting these specifications will not be judged.

Judging criteria:

1. Category relevance – is the shot on subject, or should it be in a different category.
2. Technical competence/excellence – is the shot exposed well – right balance of dark and light, no burn out. Is depth of field used well/is the shot appropriately focused.
3. Creativity – what is different about the shot. Does an idea/story come through in the shot. Does it draw the viewer in/ have emotional impact. What makes it more than just a pretty snap - unusual angle, choice of exposure settings, inclusion (or exclusion) of person or object to give context.
4. Difficulty to shoot – dawn/dusk, challenging light, difficult to reach angle.

1. and 2. are essential just to be accepted in category. 3. is what will define a winner, unless there are two winners, in which case 4., while not essential, might be the decider.

Prizes will be awarded to the best photo in each category.

Peter Laurenson has been a judge for the Wellington Section Photo competition for the last 4 years.

From hiking and trekking beginnings he joined the NZAC in 2002 and has since become an occasional climber. Since 2004 he has won several Wellington Section and National NZAC annual photo competition awards, including the Overall winner (John Harrison memorial trophy) in 2014.

Peter has published a photographic book, Occasional Climber – a journey to Mount Clarity and a website www.occasionalclimber.co.nz, where you can view his images, mostly presented geographically as route-based slideshows. Also on the site is a presentation about [outdoor photography](#) that might help to inspire your creativity and entries to the competition.



Reflections, taken from Shorefront of Lake Tekapo
Peter Ambrose, Winner, Alpine General and People's Choice Overall Winner 2017



Trip Reports

Another great day in the mountains

Climbing Te HeuHeu's SE Ridge
Words and pictures Peter Laurenson

Just as I thought what lay above wasn't the prettiest icescape I'd seen, Simon paraphrased for me. "This ice is shit." He was busily hacking away at brittle rime ice on steep volcanic rock. Ice fragments flew everywhere. There did appear to be a kind of shelf system zigzagging up from our point at 2,670m towards the summit of Te HeuHeu, some sixty metres higher. But yes, it wasn't pretty.

Kathy looked sheepishly at me and said "I don't want to stop you climbing it, but I'm going to bow out of that." She'd battled up two earlier steep, exposed icy sections lower on Te HeuHeu's southeast ridge, pushing her cramponing and axe work beyond her prior experience. I can't think of many grandma's that could get as far as she had already that morning, so had no problem with her not wishing to follow Simon.

There were five in our party as we set off from the TASC lodge under full moonlight at 7am. Simon Williamson, partner Caro, son Felix, Kathy Ombler and I. The sky was beautifully clear, but the breeze was nippy, progressing to bitey as we ascended. Our intended route was the southeast ridge, which presents a very aesthetically appealing profile from the lodge door. The snow squeaked under our crampons – lovely.



The first section up through Tukino Ski field was very straightforward – good terrain to generate some body heat for warmth. As we reached a ridge at about 2,000m on the north side, a molten orb breached the eastern skyline, treating us to some alpenglow on steroids.

Otherworldly scalloped snow caught the low angled rays, creating a luxuriant scene at our feet that just stretched away to the horizon around us. Our route lay ahead, bathed in mauve.

Left - at the base of the ice cliff at 2,670m

One of the beauties of club trips is that more experienced climbers help less experienced ones push their boundaries. In this case I'd invited Kathy to join our party at the Wellington Section Tukino ice climbing meet. It was a chance for her to get into a winter ice headspace before she joined an Adventure Consultant's ice climbing course down south. So naturally, when conditions became more demanding at about the 2,400 metre mark, I took on an informal guiding role. And that upped the challenge for me too, requiring me to take direct responsibility for the safety of another. My rope work is a fair way south of slick, but I managed to effectively protect her on a short steep exposed pitch, followed by a section of short roping, until we reached a second steeper pitch that Simon had already led up and protected.



From the ski field we traversed across to the lower southeast ridge and began gaining height in earnest. Conditions were really good, but our first little challenge presented at 2,400m, where the icy wind had scoured away the snow, leaving a hard steep section of ice with a yawning drop below. Simon, Caro and Felix forged ahead while Kathy and I enjoyed our first pitch of the morning. That followed shortly after by our second, which was on the line of ice cliff that stretches horizontally right, appearing to be about three quarters of the way up the route, when viewed from TASC Lodge.

Simon belayed Felix up first and then decided he'd had enough of standing in the persistent, icy wind. "Dad says all three get on the rope" yelled messenger Felix through the spindrift. Hmmm, well, okay then. Soon Caro, then Kathy and I, bringing up the rear, climbed up the steep chute of rime ice. The very start of the chute was the crux, where having a top rope paid dividends.



Looking to Te HeuHeu (2,732m) from the exposed summit of Tukino (2,720m)

By late morning we gathered at the base of the final ice cliff and agreed that Kathy and I would bypass the cliff, traversing right, underneath until it relented and became the west ridge.

The others would do battle with the rime ice. Kathy and I reached the top soon after, enjoying an unimpeded panorama. There's so much more to Ruapehu's terrain than "volcano" suggests.

We enjoyed this until the wind drove us down to the saddle between Te HeuHeu and Tukino. As we did so, two figures appeared from where we'd come up earlier, scampered up the final stretch to Te Heu-Heu's summit, then disappeared.

Kathy and I waited in the calm of the saddle, expecting to see three other figures emerge on top any moment. As time dragged those other two climbers didn't reappear either. I anguished about whether we should push on without them or not. We hadn't actually discussed what our now split party would do beyond the summit.

While we waited I suggested we climb up onto the top of Tukino, just twelve metres lower than neighbouring Te HeuHeu. This was my third time up Te HeuHeu and, until then, I'd never bothered to visit Tukino's summit. I'm glad we did, because it's a spectacular spot – a narrow outcrop of rime ice with sheer drops on three sides.

Climbing the western side of the summit ridge of Te HeuHeu, here at about 2,700m. Ruapehu's summit plateau unfolds behind





At about 2,600m
on the SE Ridge

The others still hadn't appeared on top of Te HeuHeu, but we reasoned that they were three and well experienced. They must be fine, so began our descent down the west ridge to Ruapehu's Summit Plateau. As we trudged towards the top of Mangatoetoenui Glacier three waving figures appeared above the ice cliffs. It was good to know for certain they were also on their way down.

As we plugged down the glacier the effect of the bright winter sun was evident. The firm conditions of the morning had gone. Now we had to be mindful of avalanche risk as we passed the convex snow bulge on the upper glacier. About 4pm we again reached the ski field, closing our day's loop.

Back in the warmth of TASC Lodge, sipping red wine that evening, we learnt that, due to the "shitiness of the ice", Simon had run out of ice screws short of Te HeuHeu's summit, so had to rap off, go around the traverse we'd used and then put in a top rope for Felix, so he could climb the rime. It had been Simon and Caro who were the "other two climbers" we'd seen. Ahhh-ha, mystery solved.

TASC Lodge is a treasure. You can step straight into your crampons or skis at the lodge door, wasting zero time on a tedious approach below the good stuff. The lodge is the ideal place to savour your day's exploits higher up too. Considering its 1,700 metre elevation, the extent of comfort afforded by its facilities is impressive. And then there's the lodge owner and resident alpine legend, Don French. As I sat with Don in the warm glow of the fire, sipping yet more red wine, he recounted epic climb after epic climb. Yes indeed, another great day in the mountains.



A lightshow unfolds in the early afternoon, as spindrift and the steep south face of Tukino catch the sun. Te HeuHeu is far right



For a route map and more captioned images
occasionalclimber.co.nz

Section Contacts

Powered by volunteers

We're always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. A lot goes on to keep our club going, virtually all powered by volunteers. On the back page is our "Club on a page" summary. It gives an at a glance description of all the things we do, how and why. Feel free to print a copy and pass it on to anyone who might be interested in becoming a member or volunteer. And if you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz.

Role	Name	Contact
Chair person	Simon Williamson	021 054 7684
Secretary, gear custodian	Carolyn Ellis	021 574 287
Treasurer	Vacant	
Trip co-ordinator	Eric Duggan	021 350 161
Section nights, Vertigo, Photocomp	Peter Laurenson	021 446 725
Social media	Marie Kelly	
Club liaison	Keith Munro	
Library, Projects	Alex Waterworth	
General Committee	Matt Pemberton	
General Committee	Guy Dubuis	
General Committee	Joshua Mouat	
Patron	John Nankervis	
Rock drill overseer	Jeremy Tries	027 555 5893



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New routes every week*

\$1000 worth of new holds in Jan/Feb 2012
New pad in "Da Cave" allowing safe aggressive bouldering

Creating happiness through better climbing

* to be precise, this is just an average but we do aim for new routes every single week.



HangDog Rock Climbing Adventures
453 Hutt Rd
Lower Hutt
(04) 589 9181
info@hangdog.co.nz
www.hangdog.co.nz



Ocelot
\$115



MXC 820
\$230



Makalu
\$255



Caiman
\$230

all crampons include anti-balling plates and crampon bag



i climb .co.nz



For quick access to our Section's page on the NZAC website, click or scan this QR code

Our club on a page



WHAT WE DO

FOR MEMBERS

Facilities

- * Huts
- * Gear
- * Library
- * Discounts

Training

- * Level 1- 3 winter skills
- * Summer rock
- * Instructors

Climbing trips

- * Section
- * National
- * International

FOR MEMBERS AND WIDER PUBLIC

Publications

- * Website
- * Social media
- * Vertigo
- * Guide books

Events

- * Banff mountain film festival
- * Reel Rock
- * Photo comp

Networking

- * Section nights
- * Conferences and meetings
- * Lobbying

HOW WE DO IT

Organise, encourage, support, enable

Inform, entertain, promote

OUR RESOURCES

Volunteer time and capabilities, income from events and gear hire, national office support, sponsorship

WHY WE DO IT

Connecting & developing more climbing & mountaineering people, knowledge, skills & experience, thereby ...

... building lifelong friendships

... protecting and improving access to alpine places

... sustaining and growing climbing and mountaineering achievement

... enhancing alpine safety

... building appreciation, enjoyment and protection of alpine places

Image and diagram Peter Laurensen www.occasionalclimber.co.nz